EXHIBITION

Hitting the Spot

Artist Aditya Pande mixes traditional methods with digital techniques to create his artworks

Delhi-based artist Aditya Pande's latest show of about 20 new works, 'Blind Spot', alludes to both psychological and physiological phenomena. "My art practice is centred around drawing; more as a form than as a medium. In this show, I try to build narratives that broadly claim kinship with mythology, satire, history, math and pop culture," he explains.

The largest work in the show is 'Hollow Casts of the Levant / Witness the Domestication of Pegasus / In Ashoka's Recurring Nightmare'. 'Hollow Casts' was a process employed to make toy soldiers by a company called W. Britain in the early 1900s. It is an eight-panel work divided into three segments that interconnect to read as a single continuous narrative about the mythology of Pegasus, satirising its presence in today's context. "Its appearance is intended to deceive you into believing that the work may be a celebration...my motivation for the work was guided by a sense of outrage towards the cognitive blind spots that we collectively witness," elaborates Pande.

His method involves both the manipulation of computer-aided technologies and also more traditional media. As such, an individual work may draw on the use of media as diverse as vector drawing, digital photography, ink, tinsel and acrylic paint. It took him more than half a year to produce the final works, though they had been in preparation since his last solo show, 'Saturday', also held at Nature Morte in 2019. "The gestation period for a work is very long. A kind of endless staring competition that can take the same time as the frequency of, say, the Olympics," he exclaims.

Pande's previous exhibitions have provided him the opportunity to expand his drawing practice. He began showing with Nature Morte in 2006, and his first works were giant printed sketches that looked like futuristic fossils. Thereafter, Nature Morte presented solo shows of his works in 2011, 2017, 2019 and 2022. The gallery also collaborated with the Alexia Goethe Gallery in London for his solo show there in 2009. Many shows later, and with encouragement to experiment with the form, he has produced a body of works that seeks to be both defined as well as ambiguous in terms of categorisation. "This journey continues to surprise while still not being disconnected from its past. I can only commit to surprising myself for what comes next," he concludes. ■

– Neha Kirpal





FORM & MEDIUM (clockwise from left) 'Hollow Casts of the Levant', (print on canvas); 'Alexa and her Dreams of Alexander', (print on paper); 'Notes on the Size, Shape and Location of Dante's Inferno', (print on paper)



'Blind Spot' will be on view at Nature Morte gallery in Delhi till September 8

LEISURE

A Guileless Modernist, edited by art historian R. Siva Kumar, introduces us to the life and practice of Leela Mukherjee (1916–2002), whose sculptures, prints and drawings are relatively unknown today. While Mukherjee did not leave behind a detailed inventory of her work, nor a chronological account of her life, the book attempts to gather available details in the form of photographs, exhibition catalogues and memories of friends and other artists. Interest in Mukherjee's practice is heightened through association—her husband, Benodebehari Mukherjee (1904-1980), was a revered Santiniketan modernist, and her daughter, Mrinalini Mukherjee (1949-2015), was one of the most acclaimed contemporary sculptors of India.

This volume contains a generous number of reproductions that inevitably draw the reader into comparing styles and themes across the pages, particularly amongst the sculptures in wood, where certain archetypes like the mother, the child and the lover recur. Many of the sculptures seem suspended between figuration and abstraction, as if the figure is hidden or yet-to-emerge. Art historian Shanay Jhaveri explains through a careful examination of various pieces that while Leela drew from the vocabulary of 'folk' art, it is unclear if the artist intended to also place herself in relation to Cubism or other move-